he cause to the country's national security by compromising ongoing operations? This too remains in the domain of speculation but the investigation revealed that he might have passed on over twenty thousand documents. Singh's modus operandi was simple. Bring a classified report home, photograph it with a sophisticated camera provided by the Americans, store the files in an external hard disc and later transfer them to his handler using secure internet protocol. He subsequently erased all the files from the external disc and the two laptops he frequently used to transfer the nation's secrets.

Only after his escape did the investigators from the Counter Intelligence unit start weaving together threads from his past. Right on top were his frequent trips to Nepal. Although the counter-espionage unit operatives did not have elaborate details of the people Singh interacted with in the Himalayan country, they had reason to believe that his trips there were primarily to meet the Americans, especially the CIA station chief at Kathmandu who was working under the cover of Counselor, Economic Affairs. Later, the R&AW agents learned that days before he flew to Washington, Ra-binder Singh and his wife Parminder had been booked into a hotel in Nepalganj, close to the Indian border and the CIA station chief had paid the bill. The two were then shifted to a CIA safe house in Kathmandu and two American passports were issued in the names of Rajpal Sharma and Deepa Kumar Sharma. On 7 May 2004, an American escorted them on board the Austrian Airlines Flight 5032 headed to Washington.

Spying is the product of betrayal. Someone in the business needs to betray a country, organisation or source to acquire protected intelligence. Rabinder was a seasoned spy and a double agent. He was trained in the craft of surveillance